

RABBI'S RULE

"When the King is singleton offside, play the Ace." This is a SAFETY PLAY.

South opens 1♠ and partnership reaches 4♠.

Declarer has 10 sure tricks WITHOUT touching the diamond Queen — solid trumps, the heart Ace, and a club winner — but the diamond suit is the trap.

- AQxxx in declarer opposite xxx in dummy. The King is missing.
- West has the SINGLETON K. East has Jxxx.
- Take the safety play: cash the Ace. The stiff K drops; the Q is established as a small bonus, but more importantly you never give up the lead. Contract makes.

- Try for an overtrick by finessing: lead toward the AQ and play the Q. West's K wins. Now West can put East in, and East cashes long hearts. Contract goes down — at least 1, sometimes more.

The lesson: COUNT your top tricks before deciding any finesse. If you already have enough to make, the finesse is gratuitous risk — and Rabbi's Rule (cash the Ace) is the safer play.

Things to think about:

- What's your trick count BEFORE you touch diamonds?
- Where is the danger hand for cashing — east or west?
- Does the auction (silent opps) say anything about diamond distribution?